vibes

Application
Innovation Challenge 2026

STUDENT WELL-BEING · BENIN

Makes lives happen.

A light, student-built app that helps university students put the phone down and find their people, their pace and their habits, in real life.





Team VIBES · UNSTIM, Abomey, Benin
Three students aged 19 to 21
Mathematical Engineering and Modelling

Submitted to

Education Training Research etr.

YTH LIVE GLOBAL 2026

AT A GLANCE

One idea, in one page.

Imagine a generation that puts the phone down, not out of obligation, but because something better is waiting outside. **VIBES is the first step toward that world.**

1 The problem

Students lose nights to the scroll. Nothing as attractive waits outside, and few dare to say what they need. A very connected generation, and a very lonely one.

2 The people

University students at UNSTIM first, then other campuses in Benin. Priority: tight budgets, long commutes, newcomers, and anyone who hesitates to show up alone.

3 The idea

A lightweight web app with three gestures: **Discover** shared passions and activities, **Equip** yourself with a private space and tips, **Anchor** small habits.

4 The value

A first step that is easier: find a small group, know the real cost before going, take a private moment, and get pointed to trusted help when it is too much.

5 The difference

Most apps win when you stay. VIBES wins when you leave. Success is measured in **lived hours**, not screen time.

6 The plan

We build the MVP ourselves. The award funds what comes next: wider surveys, a youth-led awareness campaign, a supervised pilot and a safe foundation.

3
months of design work led by students

100+
students surveyed on campus since 21 September

10
mockup screens and a Design System v1

The survey is a first field check, not a representative sample. It is why we want to extend it to other schools.



Less scroll.
More life.
More us.

THE CHALLENGE

The scroll became their only option.

Our observation on campus is not "young people scroll too much". It is that **nobody helps them listen to themselves**, and nothing as appealing waits outside. The problem has four layers, from the most visible to the deepest.

1 Attraction

Scrolling is designed to hold you. A student who stays is not lacking willpower; they face apps built to keep them.

2 The void

When the phone goes down, they do not know what to do that is as good, or with whom. So they go back.

3 The silence

Young people know what they need: talk, move, meet, create. What is missing is a place to admit it without being judged.

4 The invisible

Well-being tools exist, but many students do not know them, or do not see themselves in them.

WHAT THE DATA SAYS

1 in 6
people worldwide is affected by loneliness (WHO, 2025)

17–21%
of people aged 13 to 29 report feeling lonely (WHO, 2025)

24% / 11%
reported loneliness in low-income vs high-income countries (WHO, 2025)

55.9%
of 766 students of the Faculty of Health Sciences in Cotonou showed depressive disorders in a published study. Associated factors include difficulty adjusting and thinking of dropping out. *This concerns one health faculty and depression, not all students; it shows that student well-being in Benin is a real subject.*

The WHO also calls for technology that strengthens human connection instead of weakening it. That is the line VIBES takes.



Sources: WHO news release, 30 June 2025; Klikpo et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020. Full list on the last page.

OUR RESPONSE

Three gestures. Another way to live campus life.

VIBES is prevention, designed by students. We test every feature with one question: **did the young person spend less time on the screen and more in real life?**

Discover

Find young people who share your passions: football, music, anime, photography, choir. Join events, clubs, or a small **Crew** so the first time is never alone.

Equip

My Safe Place: a private space to note your mood and receive small, practical gestures. **Tips VIBES**: short cards written by young Beninese people, in their words.

Anchor

Small **Étincelles (Sparks)** instead of pressure: a walk, a message to a classmate, a screen-free break. No streaks, no rankings, no guilt.

WELL-BEING IN FIVE DIMENSIONS

Social · Physical · Emotional · Mental · Food

Activities are the means, not the goal. The goal: a young person who feels less alone, more energetic and more confident, with the habit of taking care of themselves.

OUR VISION

A student arrives in an unfamiliar city. Within days they have found young people who share their passions, a group to play football with, and a place to say how they are. They feel at home. And this well-being depends neither on their money, nor their contacts, nor luck.



A language of our own

"On se VIBES ?" replaces "On sort ?". The vocabulary will be tested with young people before it is adopted. Everything written in the app is drafted and polished by a youth editorial committee.

THE EXPERIENCE

Made for the real moments of student life.

Technology opens the door. Experiences are lived outside.



Explore activities

Sport, culture, relaxation, solidarity. Real cost, date and place shown up front.



Join with confidence

Public place, identified organiser, all levels welcome.



Go with a Crew

A small group around an activity. A chat only for people signed up, no private messages.



Take a moment

Mon Mood and My Safe Place. Optional, private, no score, no diagnosis.



Tips VIBES

Short cards, written with young Beninese people, health content reviewed.

How it plays out

1. You spot an activity that speaks to you.
2. You join a small group to get organised.
3. You meet up in person, for real.

Screens are working mockups and are subject to change. They show the direction; the first web MVP is being built.

WHAT SETS US APART

A platform that wins when you leave it.

OUR CENTRAL INDICATOR

Lived hours

The real hours of matches, walks, choir rehearsals and creating that VIBES helped trigger, confirmed on the spot. Time in the app is tracked only as a warning signal: if it rises without lived hours rising too, we fix it.

What we do differently

- Answer all four layers, not only the screen
- A place to tell the truth, without judgment
- A small group removes the fear of coming alone
- Content in the students' own words
- Real cost, distance and data use shown before you commit

These are our hypotheses. We do not claim that no other solution exists: a benchmark of existing solutions in Benin and West Africa is part of the project. WhatsApp groups and club pages already do part of the job; VIBES builds on them as channels.

YOUNG PEOPLE LEAD

A Adéyinka Laurinda ADANLAO
Machine learning engineer in training

P Prosper AFFOUKOU
Team lead · Systems Thinker and Data Scientist

A Abel KPOKOUTA
Full Stack developer and video maker

Three students aged 19 to 21 in Mathematical Engineering and Modelling at UNSTIM. Systems thinking, data analysis and development: this is what makes our plan realistic and measurable.

How young people shaped the idea

The idea comes from what we see around us. We have tested it in the field since 21 September, with 100+ responses and a very positive welcome. Interviews and mockup tests with students are next. All app text is written by a youth editorial committee.

Health content is reviewed

We come from maths, not health. Final-year medical students already review health content. With the award, licensed health professionals will supervise it.



BUILT IN FROM THE DESIGN

Made for here. Safe from the start.

WHO MIGHT BE LEFT OUT, AND OUR ANSWER

Barrier	Our response
Little mobile data, older phone	Lightweight web app, compressed photos, optional SMS or WhatsApp reminders
Tight budget	Filter by real cost, free activities first, shared transport inside the Crew
Far from campus	Distance filter, activities on site
Language	French first, written with young Beninese people; local languages being studied
Shyness, disability, first-generation students	Beginner-friendly activities, accessibility information shown, accompanied first visit

SAFETY, PRIVACY, MISINFORMATION

Activities

Public activities only, in small groups for the first time. Student events are checked before publication; the most exposed ones require a public place, daytime hours and posted rules.

Crew chat

Only for people signed up, no private messages, no phone numbers shown, reporting available, closed 48 hours after the event.

Data

Minimum collected. No precise location shared between strangers. What you write in My Safe Place is private. Feelings questions are optional. Photos private by default.

Reliable information

Tips written by young people, reviewed by professionals for health content. Organisers are verified.

When it is too much

A "Need help now?" access stays visible on every screen and points to a trusted person or service. Ambassadors are trained in listening and referral. The whole system is tested with young people before any wide opening.

A clear limit

VIBES is a prevention and well-being initiative. It is not a care service, not a diagnostic tool, not medical or psychological advice, and not a dating app. No notification pressure: two a day by default (morning and evening) plus reminders for events you joined. No challenge on tobacco, alcohol, drugs or betting without a professional, and none on restrictive eating or weight.

THE PLAN

We build first. The award takes it to the next level.

Already here

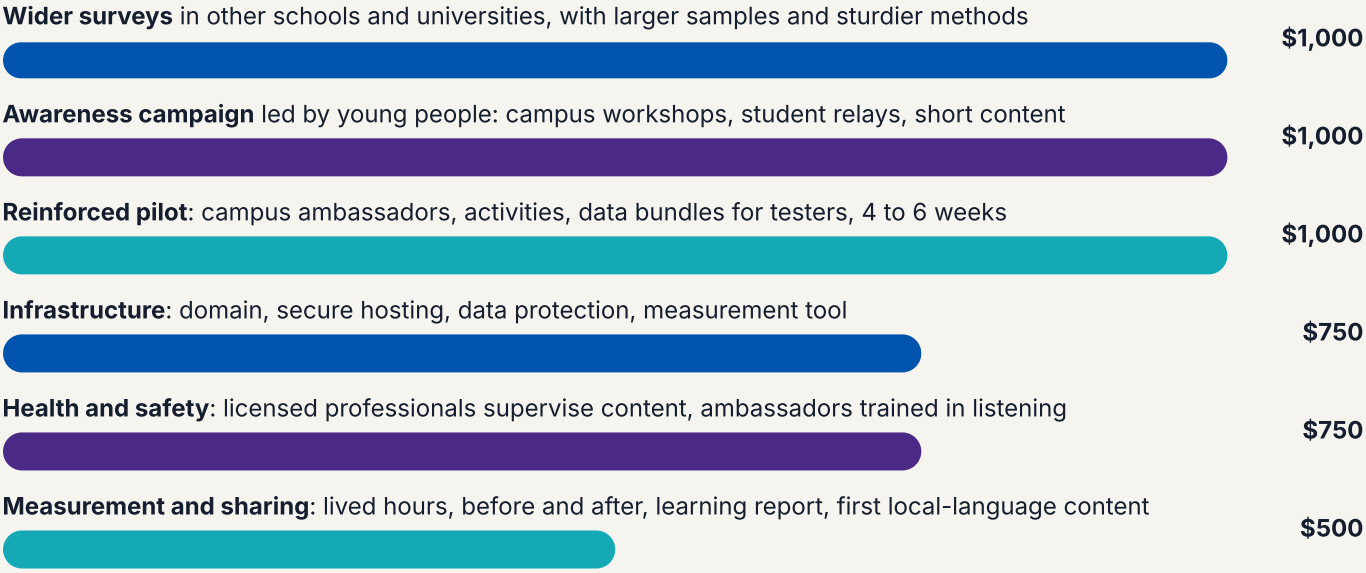
- Project design document
- Design System v1
- 10 mockup screens
- Campus survey since 21 September

We fund and build ourselves

- The lightweight web MVP
- Interviews and mockup tests with students
- First field work on campus

The award does not start VIBES. It carries it from a prototype on one campus to a solid base for several universities.

WHAT $5,000 MAKES POSSIBLE (PROPOSED ALLOCATION)



If the award is smaller. At $2,000 or $1,000 we keep the same split and scale the pilot down: fewer campuses, fewer testers, a shorter run. The MVP stays self-funded either way.

THE PILOT QUESTION

Do students who use VIBES feel more connected after a few weeks, come back on their own, and take up new habits? We measure with two or three short questions before and after, a well-being tool validated with professionals, and total lived hours. **No result is claimed at this stage.**

INDICATORS

Lived hours · self-reported well-being (connection, confidence, participation) · students who return on their own · real participation · habits installed · accessibility and safety feedback · and, as a warning signal, time in the app.

What we give back to the YTH community

An open learning report: what worked, what did not, and anonymised survey data. VIBES is not a closed product. It is a method another campus or country can take up.

Allocation proposed by the team and open to adjustment.

WHY US, WHY NOW

We build before we ask.

We build before asking. Three months of work, field surveys, and a self-funded MVP.
We see the problem up close. We know those screen nights, those empty weekends, and the fear of the first step.

We know how to measure. We say what the data does not prove.
We start from the ground. Our campus, its habits, its WhatsApp groups.
We go against the grain. An app judged by what it gives back.

HOW VIBES ANSWERS THE SELECTION CRITERIA

Criterion	Our answer	Page
Relevance	Student isolation and screen overuse, described in four layers with WHO and Benin data	3
Youth leadership	Three students aged 19–21 lead; a youth editorial committee writes all content	6
Usefulness	Find a group, know the real cost, take a private moment, build habits	2, 4, 5
Innovation	Success measured in lived hours; the app is judged by how well it sends you offline	6
Feasibility	Self-funded MVP; award mapped to a 4–6 week supervised pilot	8
Access	Light web app, cost and distance filters, French first, beginner-friendly	7
Safety	Private data, verified organisers, reviewed health content, help access on every screen	7
Clarity	One page summary, annotated screens, a clear plan and budget	2, 5, 8

What if the next good thing started here?

On se VIBES ?
charmel7.github.io/vibes

Photos: Iwaria Inc and Muhammad-Taha Ibrahim via Unsplash. Sources: WHO, 30 June 2025 (who.int); Klikpo T. et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020 (doi 10.5281/hsd.v21i1.1753). Screens are mockups subject to change.